



ACCESSORY LIFTS BUILD THE MAIN LIFTS

TRAINING GUIDE

Why the work around your squat, bench, and deadlift decides how far they go.



TRAINING

Accessory Lifts Build The Main Lifts

Why the exercises around your squat, bench, and deadlift often determine how far those lifts can go. Build weak points. Build muscle. Build a bigger total.

The Big Idea

Your competition lifts and primary strength movements are the skill you are trying to improve. Accessory lifts are the tools that build the muscle, positions, control, and weak-point strength that allow that skill to keep progressing. If you only hammer the main lift, you can get better at performing it - but eventually the same weak links keep showing up.

Your main lifts show you the problem. Good accessory work helps solve it.

Why Accessory Lifts Matter

1. They add muscle where you need it. Strength is specific, but muscle gives you more potential to produce force. Well-chosen rows, presses, split squats, hamstring work, triceps work, and upper-back work can add size to the exact muscle groups that support your main lifts.
2. They attack weak points without endlessly maxing the main lift. If your bench stalls near lockout, stronger triceps may help. If your squat folds forward, more quad, upper-back, trunk, or positional work may be useful. If your deadlift struggles off the floor or above the knee, accessories can target the ranges that are limiting you.
3. They let you accumulate productive volume. Heavy squat, bench, and deadlift work creates a lot of fatigue. Accessories allow you to perform additional hard training with loads and movements that are often easier to recover from - one of the main ways you create the adaptations needed for long-term progress.
4. They build control and resilience. Single-leg work, controlled eccentrics, rows, carries, and trunk work can improve stability, coordination, and tolerance to training. A balanced program helps prepare more tissues and positions for the demands of heavy lifting.

Most Lifters Don't Push Accessories Hard Enough

A common mistake is treating accessory work like the part of the workout that happens after the 'real' training is finished - rushing through three sets of rows, leg curls, or triceps extensions with a weight you could have done for several more reps. That is movement, but it is not always a strong enough stimulus. For



hypertrophy-focused work, the set usually needs to become genuinely challenging with clean technique.

TOO EASY	PRODUCTIVE
Stopping because the target rep number was reached, though 5+ good reps were still available.	Finishing most working sets with roughly 1-3 good reps left when the goal is muscle and local strength.
Using momentum or shortening the range just to move more weight.	Progressively loading the movement while keeping the target muscle and technique honest.
Changing accessories constantly before you can measure progress.	Keeping useful movements long enough to add reps, load, control, or range over time.

Hard Does Not Mean Reckless

- Compound accessories: often live around RPE 7-9, depending on the phase, exercise, and fatigue.
- Isolation accessories: can often be pushed closer to technical failure because the systemic cost is lower.
- Progression: earn more reps or load while maintaining the standard of execution.
- Exercise selection: choose movements because they address a need - not because they look impressive.

Accessory Work Should Have a Job

MAIN LIFT ISSUE	POSSIBLE ACCESSORY FOCUS
Bench stalls off the chest	Pecs, paused pressing, controlled dumbbell pressing
Bench stalls at lockout	Triceps, close-grip pressing, extensions
Squat lacks leg drive	Quads, split squats, leg press, belt squat
Squat loses position	Upper back, trunk, tempo/paused squat variations
Deadlift struggles through hinge	Hamstrings, glutes, RDLs, back extensions
Deadlift position breaks down	Lats, upper back, trunk, controlled hinge variations

The Tensor Strength Standard

Treat accessory lifts as training - not filler. Know why the exercise is in the program, perform it with intent, track it, and progress it. Your squat, bench, and deadlift should receive the highest level of specificity, but the work surrounding them builds the body capable of handling bigger weights.

Do not just practice being strong. Build the muscle and weak-point strength that makes you stronger.

Educational content only. Training should be individualized to your experience, goals, recovery, and injury history.